

Backlashes to Gender Equality and Authoritarian Populism in the U.S.

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journals.sagepub.com/home/prqStan Oklobdzija¹  and Christopher Witko^{2,*}

Abstract

According to recent scholarship, backlash toward gender equality is fueling support for the authoritarian and populist right in many countries and, perhaps, the rise of Trumpism in the U.S. Yet, there are potentially different types of backlash to gender equality. We argue that the rising status of women over the past several decades may result in anti-feminist attitudes, not just among older men who yearn for the traditional gender arrangements of their youth as some scholars argue, but also among younger, single men lacking college degrees, who are less attractive partners for women. We call this “mate-value backlash.” Using ANES data, we find that anti-feminist attitudes have long been associated with support for Republican presidential candidates, but only in recent years have these attitudes become more prominent among unmarried men, without college degrees.

Keywords

gender, voting behavior, populism, public opinion, partisanship

Introduction

Right-wing populism and an embrace of authoritarianism are a growing force in many affluent democracies (Gidron and Ziblatt 2019; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2019; Noury and Roland 2020). Despite many studies, there remains uncertainty over what exactly contributes to growing support for these movements, parties and politicians. Some scholars debate whether economic or cultural factors are of primary importance in the rise of right-wing populism worldwide, and Trumpism specifically in the U.S. (Morgan 2018; Mutz 2018; Rodrik 2021). We argue that major advances by American women and changing economic and social relations between the sexes have contributed to a backlash that is fueling support for the Republican Party (GOP), and especially Donald Trump.

Right-wing populism and authoritarianism have received much attention, but most studies of the phenomenon have focused on the electoral politics of Europe (Scheiring et al. 2024). The U.S., with its two-party system, has not seen the formation of new radical right parties, like Spain’s Vox, Germany’s Alternative für Deutschland, Hungary’s Fidesz or France’s Rassemblement National. Nevertheless, according to some observers, the rise of Donald Trump as the standard-bearer of the Republican Party has turned that party into a de facto version of the above-named European political

movements, complete with an embrace of ethno-nationalism, anti-immigrant stances and a disdain for the laws and norms on which a democracy functions (Arhin et al. 2023; Hacker and Pierson 2020).

To be sure, right-wing authoritarianism is far from new in the U.S. (Goebel 1997). However, the reemergence of this force in recent years is perhaps driven by somewhat different factors than in earlier periods, when Americans embraced authoritarian politics (Epperly et al. 2020; Mickey 2015). Numerous studies have focused on racial and anti-immigrant backlash, which are certainly an ongoing part of right wing radicalism throughout U.S. history (Baccini and Weymouth 2021; Jardina 2019; Maggio 2023). Here, however, we focus on how

¹School of Public Policy, University of California, Riverside, Riverside, CA, USA

²UC Center Sacramento, University of California, Davis, Sacramento, CA, USA

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Corresponding author:

Stan Oklobdzija, School of Public Policy, University of California, Riverside, 4133 Interdisciplinary South, Riverside, CA 92521, USA.
Email: stano@ucr.edu

changing gender statuses and relations may contribute to support for the authoritarian right in the U.S.

Existing research shows that sexist attitudes are associated with support for Trump in the voting booth (Cassese and Barnes 2019; Deckman and Cassese 2021; Godbole et al. 2019; Ratliff et al. 2019), but there is limited research comparing support for Trump to prior candidates (Valentino et al. 2018). This prevents us from understanding whether this relationship between sexism and Republican voting has intensified over time. Furthermore, there remain some questions regarding where these gender attitudes come from and why some individuals but not others hold them, and how this may have changed over time.

Norris and Inglehart (2019) argue that surging support for radical and populist right parties throughout the globe is driven by a nostalgic, traditionalist backlash. They argue that if people yearn for the traditional gender relations of their youth, we would expect that sexist and anti-feminist attitudes and support for the radical right would be concentrated among older people. However, Schäfer (2022) finds that radical right voting is more common among younger populations in many countries. We argue that support for the authoritarian right among men could reflect, not only a nostalgic yearning for things past, but also a reaction to contemporary economic and social realities and, particularly, gender relations.

Unlike men of prior generations, young men today are not as relied upon by women for economic security, and they are increasingly competing with women for economic opportunities. In fact, due to the growing economic prospects of women, and the declining economic prospects of some young men, particularly those without much formal education, many men are less attractive partners and mates for women. Hypergamy – women partnering with men with more education and income – is a common practice in both East and West, but as women's income and education increase, these types of partnerships are becoming less possible (Esteve et al. 2016). This is arguably resulting in declining marriage rates in some countries (Chung and Lee 2022), especially among those with less education (Anelli et al. 2024; Autor et al. 2019; Binder and Bound 2019; Wilson 1996). Put simply, men with less education are the least attractive partners as women's educational attainment increases, particularly in a post-Industrial economy.

We think these conditions may lead to growing hostility toward feminism and feminists among some men, especially among single men lacking college degrees. We call this “mate-value backlash” to distinguish it from traditionalist backlash of the type envisioned by Norris and Inglehart (2019). Using American National Election Studies (ANES) data to test our arguments, we find that anti-feminist attitudes have been consistently associated

with Republican voting for a number of decades, including during the Trump era. However, only in recent years are these attitudes more likely to be held by unmarried men without a college degree, reflecting the growth of mate-value backlash, relative to traditionalist opposition to feminism and gender equality.

Our findings suggest that the demand for authoritarian populism championing regressive gender relations, rooted in current grievances rather than only traditionalist nostalgia, was largely latent until there was a candidate–Trump—that could channel those demands. This underscores the importance of both mass demand and elite supply for anti-feminist attitudes to translate into electoral gain for authoritarian populist candidates and parties. We discuss why these patterns have only recently emerged in the U.S. in more detail in the conclusion.

Economics, Culture and Gender Backlashes in the Rise of U.S. Right-Wing Populism

Support for radical right parties has been growing in many affluent democracies for some time (Kitschelt 2007). Several studies examine the causes of this rising support (Broz et al. 2021; Scheiring et al. 2024; Sipma et al. 2023; Ziblatt et al. 2023). Most can be viewed as addressing either or both the role of economic insecurity or distress, or more cultural concerns (Inglehart and Norris 2016). This debate played out in the U.S. following Donald Trump's first election as president in 2016 (Morgan 2018; Mutz 2018).

It appears clear that both economic concerns and perceived cultural status threats can fuel support for the authoritarian right (Rebechi and Rohde 2023), and that economic and cultural concerns even interact (Edelman 2021; Hopkins et al. 2024; Rodríguez-Pose et al. 2023). For example, Scheiring et al. (2024) conducted a meta-analysis of a large number of studies of the determinants of populism and found that “economic insecurity explained around one-third of recent surges in populism.” Ogorzalek et al. (2020) find that support for Trump was highest among Whites who were poorer than the national median. So, economic considerations may be important to support for the authoritarian right, including in the U.S.

Other scholars deemphasize economic factors and argue that backlash to cultural change and gains made by less powerful groups in society, resulting in social status concerns and perceptions of threat to the dominant culture, drive support for populist and radical right parties (Norris and Inglehart 2019). For example, racial antipathy and negative attitudes toward immigrants lead to voting for radical right candidates and parties (Baker and Bader 2022; Baker et al. 2020; Goodwin et al. 2022; Jardina 2019).

Others have argued that sexism and antipathy to progressive gender policies and contemporary gender relations may drive support for the radical right (Inglehart and Norris 2016; Off 2023). Right-wing populism thrives where there are challenges to the economic or social status of dominant social groups (Yadav and Mukherjee 2024). “The dominant group” often refers to a racial, ethnic, or religious group but, of course, men are a traditionally dominant gender group.

There have been major changes in gender statuses and relations in affluent democracies in recent decades, resulting from both economic changes, such as deindustrialization, and intentional efforts to increase gender equality in the economy and society. Laws and social norms have eased and destigmatized divorce, women are much more likely to be in the workforce and, in the U.S., are even now considerably more likely to attend college than men.

In short, there have been remarkable changes in gender statuses and relations with far-reaching consequences for virtually every institution, individual and household in the U.S. These changes are both cultural and economic. It would be very bizarre if social change of this magnitude did not affect political attitudes and behavior among both men and women. While prior research has noted that backlash against these types of changes may fuel support for the authoritarian right, we think there are multiple potential forms of backlash to growing gender equality. It is important to understand these different types of backlash because they lead to different expectations for the specific types of gender attitudes people will develop, and who we would expect to develop these attitudes and support the authoritarian right. Not all men have been affected by these changes to gender relations in the same way.

Varieties of Backlash to Gender Equality

Scholars have identified many different forms of sexism (Bareket and Fiske 2023; Barreto and Doyle 2023; Swim and Cohen 1997). We focus on hostility to feminism, and feminists specifically, which we expect to emerge among those discontented with contemporary gender relations. Who are such discontents?

Norris and Inglehart (2019) argue that growing support for radical and populist right parties is rooted in a sort of nostalgic traditionalism among people who prefer things the way they were when they were younger. There have been major changes in gender roles and norms in the last several decades. Most notably, women have been more likely to attend college and enter the workforce and men have been expected to play a greater role in things like child-rearing. So men and women play more (though

far from) equal roles in the household, the economy and other aspects of society.

If people think it was better when women played more of a domestic rather than economic or public role, as in past decades, and express this politically, this would be “traditionalist backlash.” It would be evident in a preference for traditional gender arrangements – like women staying home and taking care of children, and not playing a major role in public affairs – which is perhaps consistent with what scholars call benevolent sexism (Barreto and Doyle 2023). Furthermore, Norris and Inglehart (2019) argue that this traditionalist backlash should be more common among older men, since younger men do not remember a time when most women were not in the workforce, stayed home to raise children, and so forth. The idea that older people, especially men, would prefer less gender equality makes sense but, empirically, it does not actually seem to be the case that older voters have a greater preference for the authoritarian right (Schäfer 2022).

Alternatively, a second type of backlash, which we call “mate-value backlash,” may emerge from the growing economic and social parity between men and women and be more rooted in perceived self-interest. The growing economic parity of men and women means that women are less reliant on men for economic security compared to decades past. In addition, changing attitudes, social norms and more equitable laws have made it easier for women to remain unmarried. In short, women are able to more fully engage in society and the economy without male partners, making marriage less attractive. This can be seen in declining marriage rates (Anelli et al. 2024; Autor et al. 2019; Binder and Bound 2019). This is both a cultural and economic shift.

Not only do women need men less for economic security, as women’s economic prospects have increased, men and women are also competing more directly in the labor market. It is a staple in the political economy literature that workers facing new threats to their labor market position will demand government protection. From 1950 to 2000, female labor force participation rates increased from 34% to 60% (Kongar 2008; Toossi 2002). Tens of millions of women have entered the workforce since the peak of the Industrial Era. This swamps the number of immigrants who have come to the U.S. Men may very well respond to this competition with hostility toward women’s economic autonomy and ability to compete with men economically, contributing to something like hostile sexism (Godbole et al. 2019; Swim and Cohen 1997).

Taken together, these social changes – lessened economic dependence of women on men and growing economic competition between men and women, resulting in cultural changes like lower marriage rates and more single men – could fuel a political rejection of women’s increased

autonomy. But these changes do not affect all men equally. Deindustrialization and economic changes leading to stagnant or declining incomes for men without college degrees make these men especially unattractive partners for women (Schneider et al. 2018). These men are also not well equipped to compete economically with men or women, the latter who are now more likely to attend college than men (Goldin et al. 2006).

There is a debate over the extent and possible changes in levels of assortative mating – people partnering with individuals with similar levels of education – and hypergamy – women marrying men of higher education attainment – in the U.S. and other affluent democracies. Either way, during the height of the Industrial Era men with less education were *more* likely to be married than men with college degrees, but now, for men with less education, the opposite is the case (Lundberg and Pollak 2015).

The growing difficulties of some men in finding partnerships due to their relative economic potential has not been fully appreciated or systematically analyzed as a cause of anti-feminist attitudes and support for the radical or populist right in the U.S. The idea that one's value in the mating or relationship market could influence policy or political attitudes is not entirely new, however. Scholars have investigated whether competition for mates may affect attitudes toward immigration, for example, and they find that it does (Antfolk et al. 2018). In addition, Dancygier et al. (2022) find that anti-refugee violence in Germany is higher in areas where men feel that an influx of refugees makes it more difficult to find female partners.

The U.S. has seen violence with the same basic motivation. “Incels,” that is, involuntary celibates, who have a very anti-feminist ideology centered on their inability to attract romantic partners, have engaged in the mass murder of women and gender and sexual minorities on multiple occasions in recent years (Hoffman et al. 2020). Few men will commit incel-motivated violence, but these extremists are part of broader online communities (Hoffman et al. 2020), some explicitly incel and others perhaps more accurately called part of the online “manosphere.” The online incel community is built around the idea of female partners being unavailable – incel is short for involuntary celibate – which is the most extreme version of the antipathy toward gender equality that we highlight (Jaki et al. 2019). But concerns about relationships between men and women, and especially power dynamics between them, are common in the broader manosphere.

Furthermore, while extreme variants of sexism have existed for many years, indeed millennia, online communities have probably disseminated these ideas more widely, and also perhaps changed them into something more virulent. The online manosphere has diverse

elements, but it increasingly entails a “particularly toxic brand of anti-feminism” motivated by anger and a sense of victimhood with respect to women (Ging 2019). This idea of victimhood or grievance is precisely what our arguments would anticipate. For example, Farrell et al. (2019) find that difficulties with power dynamics in relationships with women are common in online manosphere communities (e.g., predator-prey and master-servant themes), and that participation in these communities is growing.

Obviously, violence and even online activism are extreme and relatively rare responses to growing gender equality and the diminished prospects of some men. But these ideas from the more extreme manosphere can filter down through podcasts, social media, social networks, and even political elites. Reactions to growing gender equality are not so salient or extreme for men involved in these forms of communication and networks, but they can perhaps nevertheless shape attitudes and behavior to some degree.

Though we focus on the U.S. here, these possibilities are not limited to the U.S., or even Western democracies. In fact, these processes may be more advanced and are more frequently studied in some East Asian countries, like South Korea (Kim et al. 2025). For example, Lee (2025) finds that Korean men who had anxiety about leading a “normal life” (i.e., stable job, marriage and children) had more sexist attitudes and were more likely to support rightwing candidates in recent elections. This is similar to what we argue here. Thus, though we focus on the U.S., our findings are likely to have implications for many countries.

Many men will not share this sense of grievance or victimhood. Armaly and Enders (2022) show that a sense of victimhood is roughly similar for men and women, and also similar for White men and other men. However, we expect to see hostility to feminism especially pronounced among men who are unmarried and lack a college degree because the latter are less attractive partners and less able to compete with women in the economy. Further, unlike single men, married men have, by definition, sufficient mate value to attract a partner. In addition, married men actually benefit economically to some degree from gender equality, assuming that their wife works, which is the case for most married men. Thus, we are able to distinguish mate-value backlash from traditionalist backlash and simple educational polarization by examining the differences between single and married men, with and without college degrees.¹

From Mate-Value Backlash to Votes

There is some variation across parties, and some right wing politicians (including, at times, Trump) actually use

women's and LGBT rights as a wedge issue to argue against immigration of certain groups viewed as having more regressive gender attitudes (Farris 2017). Yet, many radical right-wing authoritarian populist parties prefer policies that would uphold or revert to traditional gender relations, and have platforms that would strip women of their rights, and limit future gains in gender equality (Spierings et al. 2015). Research in other countries shows that people who have anti-feminist or other conservative gender attitudes are a key component of populist and radical right support (Christley 2022; Jenkins and Kim 2024; Norris and Inglehart 2019; Off 2023).

Unlike in European democracies, the American two-party system has not seen the emergence of new radical, populist or authoritarian right parties that compete to win elections. However, the Republican Party – the home of America's conservative movement throughout the modern era – has increasingly come to embrace both similar rhetoric and policy aspirations to Europe's radical right (Arhin et al. 2023; Hacker and Pierson 2020). Donald Trump, in particular, shares many similarities with right-wing populist leaders in both substance and style (Inglehart and Norris 2017; Versteegen 2024). Research also shows that sexism is a precursor of support for radical right groups in the U.S. such as the so-called “alt-right” (Banda and Cluverius 2023), which overlaps with the manosphere. There is quite a bit of heterogeneity in attitudes among Republican elites, Republican Party platforms across the states, and so forth. But there is no doubt that, on average, Republican elites have a preference for less autonomy for women and are certainly less supportive of government taking active steps to promote women's rights and equality.

To our knowledge, existing research does not directly test whether gender attitudes stemming from concerns about attracting a romantic partner or competing with women in the labor market lead to support for the Republican Party. Research does find, however, that sexist beliefs or hostile attitudes toward gender equality, even among women (Cassese and Barnes 2019), are associated with greater support for the Republican Party. Sexism may be especially associated with support for Donald Trump compared to other Republican candidates (Deckman and Cassese 2021; Godbole et al. 2019; Ratliff et al. 2019). For example, Valentino et al. (2018) do not observe any association between modern sexism and Republican voting in 2004–2012 presidential elections, but they do in 2016. In addition, Armaly and Enders (2022) find that a sense of victimhood, which is likely at the heart of the mate-value concerns we describe above, is associated with Trump support in 2016.

Given the preferences for the different parties and growing racial polarization, it is worth considering how the association between sexist attitudes and Republican

and, particularly, Trump support may vary by race and ethnicity. Restricting their analysis to White women, Cassese and Barnes (2019) find that hostile sexism predicted support for Trump in 2016, but not Romney in 2012. However, White men demonstrating hostile sexism also supported Romney at a higher rate in 2012, though this difference was not quite statistically significant. In contrast, Cassese and Holman (2019) find that benevolent sexism does not predict the Trump vote.

However, Frasure-Yokley (2018) finds that ambivalent sexism predicted the Trump vote in 2016 among White women, but not other women. Similarly, Wong (2018) also finds that among evangelicals, only White evangelicals are more likely to support Trump. So, it is possible that Whites are more likely to translate mate-value concerns and sexism into support for Trump. This potential variation in how mate-value concerns and resulting sexism shapes party voting among different racial and ethnic groups should be kept in mind.

It does seem that, perhaps because of his personal statements and actions with respect to women, more than even other Republican candidates, Trump can politically activate anti-feminist attitudes and channel these attitudes into support for himself, and by extension the Republican Party. There is, of course, a long line of research showing that the public takes cues from elites on a variety of attitudes (Lenz 2013; Zaller 1992). The online manosphere and people exposed to those ideas, discussed above, are a relatively small portion of the American public, and Trump can appeal to these individuals, but in the process Trump's statements and actions, and those of other Republican elites during the Trump era, may cue even more and stronger anti-feminist attitudes. Polarization can also make Republican-leaning voters more likely to endorse attitudes expressed by Republican elites (Druckman et al. 2013).

And, as the Republican Party pursues and enacts policies that aim to restrict women's rights and autonomy, both federally and at the state level (e.g., the federal Save Act, which will make it more burdensome for women who have changed their names at some point to register to vote, state abortion bans, etc.), policy feedback can further strengthen attitudes regarding the limiting of women's autonomy (Mettler and Soss 2004; Pierson 1993), at least among people already open to these ideas. As Strolovitch et al. (2017) point out in their discussion of racist and sexist attitudes in the 2016 electorate, the positions that party elites take on issues “such as pay equity and sexual harassment do not merely reflect but also construct party identifiers, members, and voters in particular ways.” Thus, there are likely important feedback effects between elites and masses taking place here, though we leave it to future research to fully flesh these processes out.

Mate-value backlash translating into Republican voting may be one thing that explains the somewhat strange fact that people who would benefit from Democratic economic policies are more supportive of the Republican Party. Specifically, we have seen that working class White men are much more likely to vote for the Republican Party than highly educated and high income White men today, and that this is especially the case under Trump (Carnes and Lupu 2020; Franko and Witko 2023; Zacher 2023). But, these are exactly the types of men that we expect to demonstrate mate-value backlash.

Historically, in the U.S. married people have more traditional values on feminism-relevant issues (Plutzer 1991), and, probably as a result, married people have been more likely to vote for Republican candidates compared to single people (Plutzer and McBurnett 1991). But, we think this is changing somewhat due to the presence of mate-value concerns among a segment of unmarried men, those without college degrees.

Any observer of American politics in recent years would probably agree that it seems that not only have we witnessed growing sexism or anti-feminism in the rhetoric of prominent politicians, but also more blatant expressions of racism and xenophobia. It is possible, indeed we think likely, that these types of attitudes are related to one another in a complex of attitudes and beliefs, found most often among Whites for obvious reasons. Strolovitch et al. (2017) call this set of attitudes “white heteropatriarchy.” We explore this possibility in the Appendix by examining the interrelationship between these attitudes, but in our main analysis we focus on the determinants of one part of this possible complex of attitudes, anti-feminist attitudes, and then how these attitudes are associated with support for Republican candidates. To account for the fact that Whites are more likely to hold these attitudes, we control for this factor in our statistical models.

Analysis

For our multivariate analyses we examine ANES data from 2016 to 2024, which are the Trump years, and separately ANES data from 1970 to 2012.

Outcome Variables: Anti-Feminism and Voting

First, in each analysis, we begin by examining sexist attitudes as an outcome variable. Conceptually, there are different dimensions of sexism and anti-feminism, including hostile sexism, benevolent sexism and modern sexism (Godbole et al. 2019; Schaffner 2022), along with our notions of traditionalist and mate value backlash. Questions designed to distinguish among these different dimensions do not always appear to do a good job of

doing so (Schaffner 2022). We use the feminist feeling thermometer as our first outcome variable, which we reverse so that higher scores indicate less warmth toward feminists.²

We chose the feminist feeling thermometer as our outcome measure for several reasons. One, the measure is often employed by scholars either on its own or as part of a larger index when studying sexism and how it influences vote choice (Elder et al. 2021; Knuckey and Mathews 2024; Ocen and Chojnacki 2023; Ocen et al. 2023). Second, though some questions remain about their robustness (Tyler and Iyengar 2024), feeling thermometer responses are easily interpretable. Third, several scholars studying both backlash against gender and racial equality have found that hostility towards proponents of equality³ is a key driver of voting behavior (Abrajano and Hajnal 2015; Cassese and Holman 2019; Jardina 2019; Mutz 2018). Finally, the feminist feeling thermometer was featured on the ANES since the 1970’s—though the prompt changed from “the women’s liberation movement” to “the women’s movement” in 1986 and oscillated between that and “feminists” before settling on the latter in 2000 (Cook and Wilcox 1992).

Our second outcome variable is Republican presidential voting, which is available for all presidential election years.

Explanatory Variables and Controls

Our explanatory variables are the same in each analysis, with the exception that we include the anti-feminist feeling thermometer in the vote choice analysis, along with the other explanatory variables. To test our main argument, we include a variable for whether individuals selected “Never Married” as their marital status and whether they reported possessing a 4-year college degree or above. For the models explaining anti-feminist feelings we also include an interaction of these two variables, since we expect that never married men without college degrees will be most likely to demonstrate such attitudes, if mate-value considerations are important. In addition, we control for party affiliation (whether the respondent self-identifies as a Democrat), whether someone identifies as White, and the respondent’s age, all of which affect propensity to vote for the Republican Party, and to hold anti-feminist attitudes. Note that we limit our analysis only to men for theoretical reasons.

Results

The Trump Years: 2016–2024 ANES Results

We begin by presenting results from the 2016 to 2024 ANES surveys—election cycles, in which Donald

Trump was the Republican Party presidential nominee (Table 1.) We estimate generalized linear models on male respondents using the survey package in R, incorporating survey weights to produce population-representative estimates and design-adjusted standard errors. Our key interaction of interest is a dummy variable that is coded 1 when the respondent lists their marital status as “Never Married” and another coded 1 when the respondent does not possess a bachelor’s degree or above. Included also in the full model are controls for the respondents race (White or non-White)⁴ and the respondent’s age. We reversed the feeling thermometer from the original ANES encoding such that *higher* values indicate more antipathy towards feminists.

We find no statistically discernible difference between unmarried men without BA and hostility towards feminists in 2016, but a relatively large difference in 2020 and 2024.⁵ Unmarried men with no college education rated feminists about 10 points less favorably on a 100 point scale in the two most recent ANES surveys. While men without a BA did not consistently rate feminists any lower than their more educated counterparts in 2016 or 2020, that relationship became statistically significant in 2024. We can see that among those never married, those without a BA demonstrate much more hostility to feminists. And that even among those who do not have a BA the gap in antipathy toward feminists among those who have never been married and those who have seems to have grown in 2020 and 2024, though the latter estimates are not clearly significantly different from zero. We also observe that White men have more anti-feminist attitudes in 2016 and 2020, but not 2024.

Figure 1 shows predicted ratings of feminists across three separate ANES surveys following Trump’s

emergence as the Republican Party’s standard bearer. Starting in the 2020 ANES survey and continuing in 2024, men who were both never married and who did not have a college degree reported higher feelings of antipathy towards feminists than their never married counterparts with a college education. This difference is stark – a little bit more than 10 points in both years. We also see that among those lacking a BA antipathy toward feminists appears to have grown among those who are not married, while declining slightly among those who are or have been married.⁶

The question remains as to how these attitudes predict voting. For ease of interpretation, we estimate a weighted linear probability model. We see in Table 2 that the feminist feeling thermometer predicts voting for Trump across all three cycles studied, and that the magnitude of the effect size grew in 2020 compared to 2016. Further, the fact that antipathy towards feminists is a meaningful predictor, even after controlling for party identification, is notable. These same attitudes are also likely to play a role in shaping party identification, meaning the coefficients presented are probably biased downward. Though not our main interest, note that being White is a significant predictor of voting in 2016 and 2020, but is no longer a significant predictor of support for Trump in 2024, after we control for other factors.

1970–2012 ANES Results

Now we turn to the longitudinal ANES data. Our key outcome and explanatory variable in this analysis is the feminist feeling thermometer (again reversed.) Our data stretches from 1970, the first year ANES respondents

Table 1. Unmarried men without a college degree felt more antipathy towards “feminists” than did other single men with a bachelor’s degree in 2020 and 2024, but not in 2016. Higher values equal more antipathy. Data from ANES

	2016		2020		2024	
	Simple	Full	Simple	Full	Simple	Full
Never married × No BA	0.051 (0.039)	0.042 (0.038)	0.103** (0.030)	0.104** (0.031)	0.095* (0.042)	0.091* (0.043)
Never married	−0.038 (0.031)	−0.058+ (0.032)	−0.053* (0.022)	−0.055* (0.022)	−0.084* (0.034)	−0.094** (0.036)
No BA	0.026 (0.016)	0.033* (0.016)	0.015 (0.015)	0.022 (0.015)	0.054** (0.017)	0.056** (0.018)
Age		−0.002** (0.001)		−0.001 (0.000)		0.000 (0.001)
White		0.047* (0.020)		0.048** (0.016)		−0.018 (0.020)
Num. obs.	1,658	1,616	3,283	3,168	2,131	2,049
R2	0.006	0.020	0.015	0.025	0.029	0.030

Note. * $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

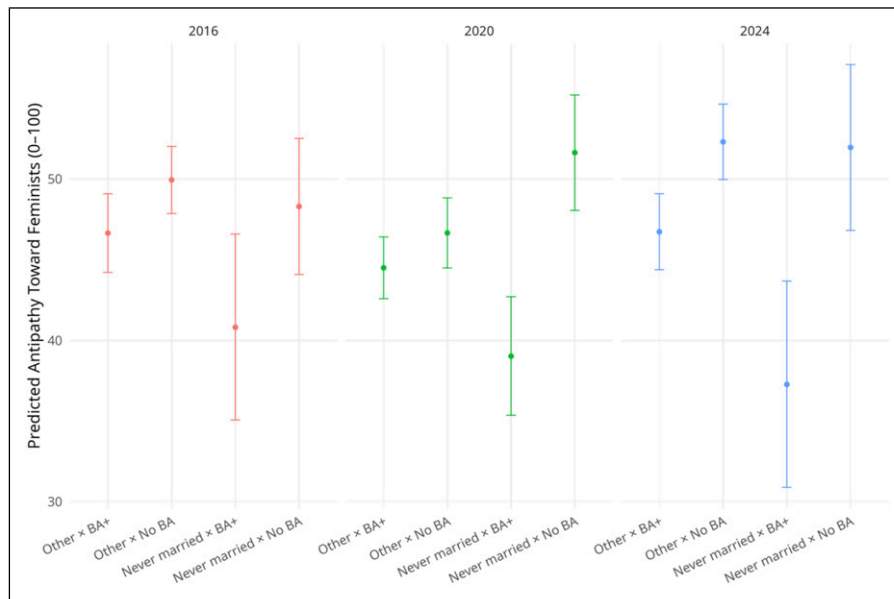


Figure 1. Starting in 2020, men who were never married and had no bachelor's degree began reporting higher levels of antipathy to feminists. The difference is considerable – about 10 points – on a scale bound by 0 and 100. Data from the ANES.

were asked to rate feminists on a scale of 0–100, and 2012, the last election when Trump was not on the ballot.

We begin by presenting the results of pooled models that examine the determinants of feminist attitudes (feminist feeling thermometer) and voting for all years pooled in Table 3.⁷ For the determinants of feminist feelings, we see divergent results from our 2016–2024 analyses. There was no statistically significant difference (at the $p < .05$ level) between feelings from

unmarried men with no college education when year fixed effects were included. However, antipathy towards feminists was a generally strong predictor of voting for the Republican presidential candidate in all elections over this 42 year period.⁸

Figure 2 shows the coefficients of the interaction between never having been married and not having a BA or above. The estimates in grey are weighted linear regressions from the ANES cumulative file from 1970 (representing the first year respondents were asked to rate

Table 2. Antipathy towards feminists was predictive of a vote for Donald Trump between 2016 and 2024. Data from ANES

	2016		2020		2024	
	Simple	Full	Simple	Full	Simple	Full
Antipathy to feminists	0.849*** (0.057)	0.350*** (0.059)	0.914*** (0.034)	0.384*** (0.047)	0.915*** (0.054)	0.237*** (0.044)
Never married		–0.066+ (0.037)		–0.034 (0.027)		–0.036 (0.023)
No BA		0.059* (0.023)		0.081*** (0.016)		0.089*** (0.019)
Age		0.001 (0.001)		0.002*** (0.001)		0.000 (0.000)
White		0.147*** (0.032)		0.129*** (0.024)		0.032 (0.023)
Democrat		–0.593*** (0.035)		–0.599*** (0.027)		–0.752*** (0.030)
Num. obs.	1,205	1,173	2,771	2,647	1769	1,681
R2	0.195	0.552	0.242	0.602	0.238	0.722

Note. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$, **** $p < 0.001$.

Table 3. Across all time periods from 1970 to 2012, neither single men nor low socioeconomic status men displayed higher levels of antipathy towards feminists than other men. During this same time period, these same men were less likely to vote for republican presidential candidates. Data from ANES 1970–2012

	Antipathy to feminists		GOP voting	
	Simple	Full	Simple	Full
Antipathy to feminists				
Never married × No BA	0.028* (0.013)	0.025+ (0.013)	0.564*** (0.016)	0.420*** (0.016)
Never married	−0.038*** (0.011)	−0.045*** (0.011)		−0.050*** (0.011)
No BA	−0.045*** (0.006)	−0.033*** (0.006)		−0.090*** (0.010)
Age group		−0.011*** (0.001)		0.033*** (0.002)
White		0.096*** (0.006)		0.089*** (0.009)
Democrat				−0.366*** (0.008)
Num. obs.	16,450	16,450	11,795	11,795
R2	0.005	0.073	0.106	0.312
R2 adj.	0.005	0.072	0.106	0.311
Year fixed effects	No	Yes	No	Yes

Note. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$, **** $p < 0.001$.

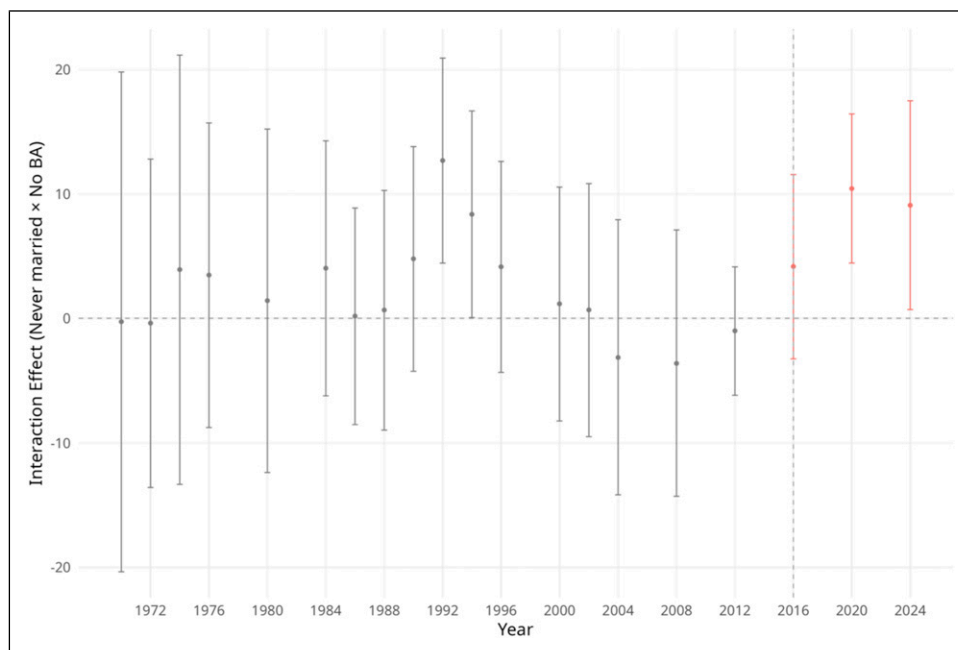


Figure 2. Interaction coefficients for “Never Married” and “No BA” for ANES surveys running between 1970 and 2024. Estimates in grey come from the ANES cumulative file and are estimated as weighted linear regressions. The estimates in red come from the individual 2016–2024 ANES surveys and are estimated as generalized linear models using the survey’s sampling design (weights, strata and clustering.) The vertical line in 2016 indicates the first election Donald Trump stood as the Republican Party nominee for the Presidency.

their feelings about feminists) to 2012. The estimates in red depict the coefficients from the regressions estimated in Table 1. With only 1992 as an exception, unmarried men with no college education did not report higher degrees of antipathy for the 32 year period in which the ANES asked the question. Following Trump’s emergence, this group of men rated feminists more poorly for two election cycles in a row.

This suggests that Trump has activated some anti-feminist attitudes among unmarried men with lower levels of education. While we can only speculate at this point, it is notable that the only other year we observe this significant relationship is in 1992, the so-called “Year of the Woman,” when many women were elected to the U.S. Senate, and there were also prominent debates about the place of women in society and politics related to questions regarding the role that Hillary Clinton might play, if Bill Clinton were elected.

Discussion and Conclusion

We have argued that changing gender relations and the relative decline in economic prospects of some men resulting from deindustrialization and social and legal changes in the last several decades leading to major cultural transformations in gender roles and relationships have led to a backlash to women’s equality and feminism.

But backlash is a vague, ill-defined concept. We posit that there are differing types of backlash to growing gender equality, but that these backlashes can be captured in negative affect toward those pushing for equal standing between men and women. At the micro-level, using ANES data we found quite a bit of support for this argument. In the most recent elections, men without college degrees have particularly strong anti-feminist attitudes if they are single and never married, which is consistent with our arguments about mate-value backlash. Thus, these results are not simply a function of having a college degree or not: they capture something beyond educational polarization.

Furthermore, it seems that this form of sexism among these individuals is relatively recent. While anti-feminist attitudes have long been associated with Republican voting, it is only in recent years that these attitudes are more likely to be found among single men without college degrees. Our findings support other recent research that shows that Trump likely had particular appeal to people with sexist or anti-feminist beliefs (Cassese and Barnes 2019; Cassese and Holman 2019; Valentino et al. 2018).

What has changed in recent years to lead to these changing patterns? While beyond the scope of this paper to definitively know, we offer three possibilities. First, women continue to make economic strides relative to

men. Women are now much more likely to graduate with a BA than men. Indeed, women's advantage in obtaining a bachelor's degree is about what men's was prior to Title IX (American Institute for Boys and Men 2024). This has led to decreasing mate-value for many men relative to the 1980s or even 1990s, and growing economic competition between men and women. Second, there is a growing recognition and weaponization of these facts on social media accounts and podcasts aimed at young men. Third, and most directly relevant to our findings, Trump was arguably more openly misogynistic than any major presidential nominee in the U.S. in many decades, and the Republican Party under Trump has become much more of an authoritarian populist party (Glick 2019; Schaffner et al. 2017). Thus, Trump very well could have cued latent mate-value concerns. These possibilities are all in need of further analysis.

In the meantime, we have found considerable empirical support for our arguments and we have made an important conceptual advance in the understanding of anti-feminist backlash and Trump, and perhaps longer-term Republican support in the U.S. We think that conceptualizing anti-feminist backlash as actually multiple different backlashes is a useful way to understand responses to changing gender relations, that have fueled Trumpism and the rightward drift of the Republican Party on gender issues in recent years. It is plausible that similar dynamics are taking place in Europe and other affluent democracies, as well, and future research should consider this.

The well of votes available from people with anti-feminist attitudes can cause politicians to pursue policies that limit the autonomy and status of women, and politicians with these views may activate such voters, leading to a cycle that results in more proposed limitations on women's equality. Arguably, this is precisely what we are seeing in both Washington, D.C. and the state capitals in recent years. The renewed and successful attempts to limit women's reproductive autonomy, with respect to abortion, taken by many state governments and the U.S. Supreme Court have received a lot of attention. But there are also attempts underway to make divorce more difficult in many states, which would directly undermine the relationship autonomy of women, and the attacks on DEI from the Trump administration and many state governments also threaten to harm gains made by women in education and the workplace. These are precisely the types of policies that we would expect to see if policymakers were trying to make women more reliant on men for economic security.

ORCID iD

Stan Oklobdzija  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8082-5824>

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Data Availability Statement

Replication materials can be found at https://github.com/StanOklobdzija/backlashes_replication_PRQ.

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. It is also important to note that it does not appear that men without a college degree are less likely to want to marry (Kuo et al. 2017).
2. Table A.6 shows the mean thermometer scores for several racial, gender and age demographics.
3. While there is a correlation between feelings towards feminists, xenophobia and racial resentment, the correlation is moderate (Cohen 2013)—ranging between 0.36 and 0.51 (see Figure A.1 in the Appendix.).
4. These results are robust to excluding non-White men from the sample. See Tables A.1 and A.2 in the Appendix.
5. Table A.7 in the Appendix further investigates this relationship by adding a separate dummy variable indicating whether the respondent earned less than the median income that year. There is no statistically discernable difference between unmarried men with a BA who earn above or below the median income.
6. We also include a dummy variable for Evangelical voters in the Appendix to control for the effect of religiosity. As Tables A.4 and A.5 show, the results are unchanged.
7. Respondent age was only available in broad, multiyear categories in the cumulative data file. However, interpreting the coefficient follows a similar logic to previous tables in this paper in that higher numbers indicate older respondents.
8. As Table A.3 shows, these results are robust to subsetting the data strictly to White respondents.

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